

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examinations 2011

CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room paper dictionaries (with the title in English).

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from either **SECTION A** or **SECTION B**.

The paper consists of **nineteen** questions in total: ten in Section A and nine in Section B.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator.
Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.
Do not open the question paper until told to do so.
All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.
All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.
At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

SECTION A

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B and one from either Section A or Section B.

1. Is sociology a science?
2. How has neo-Kantianism influenced social theory? What are the advantages and disadvantages of such approaches?
3. Identify the shared premises informing the approach of the Berger and Luckmann team and Garfinkel as the representatives of phenomenological sociology and, next, their distinct theoretical and research concerns.
4. Critical realists recognise both the external reality of societal structures as existing independently of human knowledge of them and their impact upon us. Reconstruct the main arguments behind this position and, next, discuss its implications for the nature of our knowledge about the world.
5. **Either**
 - (a) “All good science should be capable of being falsified, including social science.” Do you agree or not? Discuss with reference to Popper.**or**
 - (b) ‘Normal science’ is a barrier to scientific and social progress. Do you agree or not? Discuss with reference to Popper and/or Kuhn.
6. Scientific facts are socially created; therefore there are no universal scientific truths. Debate this assertion with reference to Kuhn and/or Latour.
7. Evaluate feminist epistemology’s challenge to traditional approaches to knowledge.
8. “‘The West’ is a conceptual construct.’ Outline and assess the implications of this statement.
9. Is post-structuralism a constructive or destructive influence on social theory?
10. Are concepts political?

END OF SECTION A

SECTION B

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B and one from either Section A or Section B.

11. Are we “docile bodies”?
12. **Either**
 - (a) How have Foucault’s analyses of power aided our broader understanding of political authority today?**or**
 - (b) Statistics are a tool of political oppression. Do you agree?
13. What is “cultural capital”? What are its advantages and limitations for analysing contemporary society?
14. In what sense are “signs” ideological?
15. Is reflexivity the key to modernity?
16. Is post-modernity a new phase of capitalism?
17. What are the challenges facing contemporary feminism?
18. ‘[A] deep chasm has opened up in the metabolic relation between human beings and nature – a metabolism that is the basis of life itself. The source of this unparalleled crisis is the capitalist society in which we live.’ Explain and evaluate this claim.
19. **Either**
 - (a) Examine the role of dialogue in social theory.**or**
 - (b) How significant have social movements been in shaping the development of social theory?

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER SC301-6-FY